Groups come first? An exploration

Final Draft of June 2023

Author's Note: I shall no longer work on this piece. I tried to do a project that balances both technicality and comprehensibility. But I now feel that I should do only one thing at a time. I still like this idea. Maybe I will develop two pieces in the future.

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October 30, 2023

Abstract: We seem to live in a disunified world where individuals usually prioritize their interests over those of groups. Introspectively, a phenomenon as such has its conceptual root, which is at least partly the platitude that individual persons are ontologically prior to social groups. What if groups are ontologically prior to individuals? My inquiry primarily concerns a group-coming-first metaphysical picture, that groups are ontologically prior to individuals. To better characterize such a relation, I advance a proposal called Group Grounding Middleism, whereupon I identify and individuate groups, and then I suggest a new conception about individual existence. In passing, deploying techniques of Group Grounding Middleism, I also develop an account of group action and a theory of group responsibility, which arguably proves advantageous in practice. I eventually conclude with a prospect of our future group-talks.

Keywords: Applied Metaphysics; Ontological Priority; Social Groups; Individuals; Middleism

1 Introductory Remarks

A usual presumption says something like this: that an individual person[1] (henceforth 'individual')—like you, me or Joe Biden—is ontologically prior to a social group (henceforth 'group')—like UC Bayern, US Army or the United Nations. Here the relation 'be ontological prior to' is primitive, whereas it may be characterized in terms of philosophical grounding[2] as I proceed. Theories in a variety of topics root in this *seemingly intuitive* notion[3]. But does the presumption, that an individual is prior to a group, construe the social world as it really is—or more fashionably, *carve* the social world *at it joints*? Arguably not. What if groups are ontologically prior to individuals? This paper is an inquiry into such a metaphysical picture, which I call a group-coming-first picture. I am primarily concerned with the ontological priority of groups over individuals. To better characterize such a relation, I advance a proposal called Group Grounding Middleism, whereupon I identify and individuate groups, and then I suggest a new conception about individual existence. In passing, deploying techniques of Group Grounding Middleism, I also develop an account of group action and a theory of group responsibility. The paper is experimental in spirit. I'm not going to try to sell this group-coming-first picture; I'm not so sure if I believe it myself. On the

[1] In what follows, 'individual' does not include non-conscious things like electrons. Nevertheless, the idea of 'individual person' could be neutral to the debate concerning personhood, i.e., intelligent aliens or intelligent non-human animals on Earth could be classified as persons.
[2] The characterization is something like "A is ontological prior to B iff B is grounded in A," and usually but not non-controversially, grounding is construed as a binary relation, which is asymmetric, irreflexive, transitive, and held between two sets of facts.
[3] For social utility, see Mill (1863), Ch. 2, secs. 9, 14, 17, 23, 25; for decision theory, see Rawls (1971), pp. 294–295, 298–299; for group action, see Gilbert (2006a), pp. 95, 99, 101, 112, 119; for group responsibility, see List and Pettit (2011), pp. 155–157; for collective responsibility, see Collins and Lawford-Smith (2016), p. 151.

contrary, I put its cons and pros on the table, leaving the choice to my readers.

Nevertheless, I plea this paper is not an idle theory-spinning. Several motivations of a group-coming-first picture are in order. The first motivation comes from Aristotelean holism. Consider two cases concerning a hand and a (healthy) body[4]. Case one, the body is destroyed and the hand is a fortiori no exception. Case two, the hand is destroyed while the body is, though harmed, not destroyed. Likewise, a group may survive when eliminating one member, but a member (of a group) cannot survive when eliminating the whole group. The second motivation comes from theoretical compatability. Though it is unlikely to defend this claim in detail here, as far as I am concerned, provided the group-coming-first picture, our previous theories utilizing individualized method are in principle adoptable, which means the cost may be lower than we expect[5]. The third motivation comes from practical benefits. Generally, theories of group action, mostly committed to an individual-comes-first stance, would face a multiple-realization-like problem, which could, however, be dismissed by an account of group action deploying techniques of Group Grounding Middleism. Meanwhile, theories of derived group responsibility usually have trouble dealing with cases of meta-injustice (e.g., the La Guardia Case) such that, by contrast, a theory of group responsibility deploying techniques of Group Grounding Middleism could accommodate. I will elaborate these two points in section 3. The fourth motivation comes from

[4] See Aristotle (1984), *Politika*, 1253 A21–24.

[5] In some cases, the group-coming-first picture may even make previous theories more plausible. For instance, the group-coming-first picture may immune the Rawlsian model of decision-making procedure (Rawls 1971, pp. 17–18) from political communitarians' criticism of neglecting the priority of community factors.

the potential support Group Grounding Middleism might provide to other theories. Recently, many attentions in practical fields—e.g., cognitive penetration, epistemic injustice, practical identity in philosophy of action, etc.—are drawn to how social factors like cultural background, power relation and surrounding environment shapes—or even determinates—the character, ability or even true self of a person[6]. To explain and defend why understanding "where we live" is so essential for knowing "who we are," friends of those theories may utilize my model of Group Grounding Middleism as a metaphysical tool, possibly further as a supporting point of why their theories could be true. The fifth motivation comes from the general picture of debates over ontological priority. Our considering arguments for and against Group Grounding Middleism—a prima facie counter-intuitive idea—can at least enhance our understanding of debates over ontological priority (especially in the context of social metaphysics), even if the idea itself proves unpersuasive in the end.

Here is my plan for this paper. In section 2, I primarily prepare my readers for the metaphysical framework of Middleism, then I put forward my proposal that an individual is grounded in his temporal slices (of actions), an individual action is grounded in its position in a group action (slice), and a group, identified and individuated by a fundamental group intention, is characterized by the collection of its action slices. In section 3, I will illustrate how explanations deploying Group Grounding Middleism, one about group agency and the other about group responsibility, could

[6] For cognitive penetration, see Silins (2016), pp. 26–29; for epistemic injustice, see Fricker (2007), pp. 71–85; for practical identity in philosophy of action, see Mele (2019), pp. 127–128.

prove advantageous in practice. I eventually conclude with a prospect of our future group-talks.

2 Group Grounding Middleism

2.1 Middleism in General

My project is inspired by a model of the hierarchical ontological structure known as Middleism (Bernstein 2021). This section works as an illustration of Middleism in general. I utilize the notion of philosophical grounding, following Bernstein, and the notion of Middleism is defined by contrast as follows:

Bottomism. The terminating level of any complete grounding chain in reality falls on the most micro level.

Topism. The terminating level of any complete grounding chain in reality falls on the most macro level.

Middleism. The terminating level of any complete grounding chain in reality falls on the middle level.

Bottomism is basically the canonical perspective. An example of Bottomism comes from mereology[7]. Some mereologists argue that ordinary objects like bricks or walls are grounded in mereological samples—undividable units that compose objects—and all composites are ontologically derived. Topism is relatively unorthodox. An example of Topism is Priority Monism. Jonathan Schaffer argues that the whole—the

[7] See, for reference, Varzi and Cotnoir (2021), pp. 2, 8, 142–145, 157.

immanently structured world—is ontologically prior to its inhabitants, e.g., physical objects, social objects, etc., whose existences are grounded in the existence of the whole (Schaffer 2010, p. 1). Middleism depicts a different image of reality. Sara Bernstein argues that, possibly, medium-sized dry goods like iPhones, tables, etc. are ontologically the most prior, which ground both entities on mass scale like planets and entities on mini scale like atoms (Bernstein 2021, p. 1069).

Motivations of Middleism include logical, conceptual and metaphysical possibility, compatability with other theories and support from physical science (ibid., pp. 1069–1070). Besides, Middleism attracts me for several reasons. To start, the structure of world in a Middleist image—the network of grounding relations—is well-founded and highly comprehensive. To continue, in contrast to macro-level entities like planets or micro-level entities like atoms, what falls in the middle-level, e.g., ordinary objects, people, etc., are relatively more common and more accessible. Further, Middleism also accommodates asymmetry, irreflexivity and transitivity of ontological priority, which partly soothes its counterintuitiveness. Back to my project, moreover, social groups are arguably the middle-level of social reality, in contrast to nations (the macro-level) or individuals (the micro-level). To this extent, the position—that groups are ontologically prior to individuals—is initially coherent with a Middleist schema. Given those reasons, I utilize Middleism—strictly put, one side of Middleism concerning the middle-level and the micro-level—to formulate my proposal.

2.2 Group as Ground

The core commitment of my proposal is that groups are ontologically prior to individuals. To characterize such relation, provided a Middleist schema, I argue that individuals are grounded in groups—more specifically, the structure of groups. Call it Group Grounding Middleism. To apply Group Grounding Middleism, provided the intuitive conception of individuals, we need a closer look at groups. To this purpose, I propose an account concerning the metaphysics of groups in this section.

What is a group? I start with one mundane understanding. Roughly, a group is a cluster of people acting in a certain way. I would reject this definition by two objections[8]. One objection is called the identity issue. Consider, for instance, the democratic party had 10^8 members yesterday and has 10^8+1 members today. There are numerically two distinct clusters, but intuitively one group only. The other objection is called the exclusivity issue. To illustrate, consider mobs and queues—even though they satisfy the mundane definition, intuitively, they could hardly be regarded as any actual group since they lack order, purpose and stability[9]. I now put my analysis on the table:

Group. For any *x*, *x* is a group only if:

1) there is a primitive, basic and maximally accommodative group intention that defines and individuates *x* from other groups;

2) there is an action slice of *x*, an ordered set whose elements are the group intention of this action and individuals or sets of individuals; the order of

[8] As notified in Effingham (2010), pp. 260–263, Ritchie (2019), pp. 402–403, etc.
[9] As is shown in the challenge concerning the content of group intention, this intuition is probably a prejudice.

individuals as elements is determined by the role they play in the action;

3) *x* has its unique structure, which is characterized as a collection of all its action slices (a set of ordered pairs) along with the bearers (members).

It looks complex. Nonetheless, I argue each condition is reasonable.

1) Intention Condition

My condition 1) says, there is a *primitive*, *basic* and *maximally accommodative* group intention that identifies and individuates a group. Call it the intention condition. It is motivated from the initial connection between intentions and actions. We may assume that actions are identified and individuated by intentions. To illustrate this point, consider me trying to win a race and me escaping from school. Those are intuitively two actions, but they could appear exactly the same in time, location, bodily motion, …, and any aspect excluding intention. Granted the action-intention connection, and given the fact that group agency is an important subject in our group-talks, group intentionality naturally gathers our attention. There are different ways to engage intentionality in a theory of group agency, e.g., joint commitment[10], selective intentionality[11] and collectively sui generis we-intentionality[12], etc. My way to engage group intentionality is simple—the identifying group intention is primitive.

Here is how the intention condition works. Let 'I_B' be the identifying group intention, 'I_I,' 'I_J' and 'I_k' be three distinct non-identifying group intentions. I_I and I_J could

[10] See Gilbert (2006a), pp. 130–131, 136, 140, 153.
[11] See List and Pettit (2011), pp. 23–24, 32–39, 52.
[12] See Searle (1993), pp. 23–26, 37–39, 46, or Searle (2010), pp. 8, 42, 43, 46–50.

be irrelevant or contrary to I_B, but they can't contradict I_B—otherwise, a new group would be engendered. Plus, for any I_I and I_J, they could be inconsistent as long as they don't contradict I_B. Consider the case of PKD (*Partei Communisms Deutsch*, the German Communist Party): in 1880, let I_B be 'we set all German people (including Jews) free from compression and enslavement," I_I be 'we provide pork in parties' and I_J be "we provide no pork in parties." I_I and I_J are inconsistent, but either is consistent with I_B. Then in 1930, let I_k be "we eliminate the German Jews." I_k is contradictory with I_B; in this case, we should say the group is not the previous PKD anymore—in fact, the group was then a part of Nazi Party, only bearing the name 'PKD.'

I now consider several challenges. One challenge concerns the content of group intention—both the identifying group intention and specific intentions in particular actions. The content of group intention could be clear[13]—like the identifying intention of the United Nations is supposedly "maintain the peace of world"—while the content of group intention could also be obscure—like it is not clear what the intention of British white-collars could be. My proposal may avoid problems such like by stipulating that each group, in general or in a certain action, has an intention in principle. I acknowledge the ad-hocness, but that should be the price for Group Grounding Middleists. An immediate concern is, moreover, why should British white-collars, if lacking a clear intention, be regarded as a group. My reasoning goes like this. People distinguish paradigmatic groups like a political party, given a certain standard, from

[13] The clarity of intention, as I understand, is such that an intention is representable in language, comprehensible, and apt for differentiation. I do not intend to invite debates over the content of mentality in general here, though arguably, the ineffability theory of mental content may prove helpful for my proposal.

ambiguous gatherings like a "Black Live Matters" parade to the mere sum of pedestrians on a street. But the standard of such a distinction—partly, having a clear intention or not—is arguably biased. Recall that the introduction of group intention aims, at least partly, at capturing group agency[14] such that a group is apt for being held morally responsible[15] for specific actions. As I will catch up in the second challenge beneath, since a queue can cause a traffic jam consciously (by "consciously" I mean "not completely a coincidence"), perhaps people may regard it as a group agent. Similarly, since British white-collars can cause a strike, a technology revolution, etc. consciously, it is reasonable to take British white-collars as a group agent, too. By the way, provided the clear-obscure distinction in group intention, I don't mean each group, all aspects considered, should be taken equally. However, it is discriminative to deny the existence of agency or group identity, merely for the absence of clear intention.

Another challenge concerns mobs and queues. Given previous challenge regarding the content of group intention, it is dubious why mobs and queues can't have vague identifying intentions. My strategy might be admitting mobs and queues as groups—our platitude, that mobs and queues are chaotic, purposeless and unstable, might be biased (cf. my response to the first challenge). As a consequence of my loosening, our social world composed of groups would be relatively overpopulated, whereas I do not find the consequence discouraging. I might also stipulate that there

[14] As notified in List and Pettit (2011), pp. 2–8.
[15] Unless otherwise notified, 'responsibility' in this paper refers to moral responsibility.

are group intentions for mobs and queues, which seems adoptable, too, given my primitivist stance—that the identifying group intention is primitive.

A third challenge concerns the relation between basic and non-basic group intentions. My tentative account is that non-basic group intention are logical consequences of basic group intention. To illustrate, the group intention of a philosophy department is that "we help acquire and spread truth and knowledge" (referred as 'φ'), other intentions of particular actions like ζ "we popularize our perspectives," η "we publish on top journals" should be substitutable for '□' in conditionals like "if φ then □" or "if φ then …, …, then □." E.g., in given illustration, non-basic group intention ζ matches the conditional "if φ, then ζ," and non-basic group intention η matches the conditional "if φ, then ζ, then η." However, it may appear that a group could occasionally perform irregular actions guided by intentions inconsistent with or even contradictory to its basic intention. For instance, let the basic intention of one nation's army be "protecting her issues and territories," one day it could kill her people, which is arguably guided by something like "help our general seize power." My response is this case may involve multiple groups—the army protecting the nation is one group, while the army rebelling the government is another group.

The last challenge concerns that group intention without the phenomenology of mind. I grant the phenomenology of mind to be the consciousness called likeness/qualia in philosophy of mind. Individuals experience phenomenology of mind. Individuals are grounded in groups. Groups don't experience phenomenology of mind.

Through this line of reasoning, group intention as ontologically prior intention seems mythical. I admit it is fair criticism. The response I want to present is a weak defense[16]. I argue this line of reasoning is, even not false, anthropomorphizing, misleading and invalid. One hidden premise of this argument is individuals have intentions with phenomenology of mind, therefore, anything that has an intention should simultaneously experience phenomenology of mind. In response, I may argue that intention is typically embedded in multiple, interwoven quilts of partial, future-directed plans of actions (Bratman 1999, pp. 2–3, 9–10, 12, 15, 37). To that sense, group intention is procedural, not phenomenological. As for how does the grounding relation hold between group intention and individual intention—which are heterogeneous—I believe it is the subject of another project (cf. footnote no. 14). And I will ignore this issue here.

2) Action Condition

My condition 2) says, an action slice of a group is an ordered pair such that the first element is the group intention of this action, and later elements are individuals or sets of individuals (where the order of individuals as elements is determined by the role they play in the action). Call it the action condition. It is primarily motivated from our conception of group structure. In one way or another, especially given the

[16] A strong defense would inevitably appeal to more controversial thesis, e.g., the embodiment theory of group identities (Fine 2020, pp. 81–82), or the information theory of mentality (Chalmers 1996, Ch. 8). I decide to not propose it here for its omissible contribution to the central topic of this paper.

exclusivity issue, philosophers generally believe that groups have structures, which is crucial for distinguishing groups from mere aggregations. There are different ways to characterize the structure of group, e.g., groups as ordered pairs[17], groups as sets[18], groups as network of relations[19], groups as fusions of pluralities[20], etc. My way to characterize the structure of group is to construe groups as sets of ordered pairs, provided the convenience of set theoretical language and an intuitive notion that order matters (consider two cabinets made of same ministers with different offices, where order plays a vital role for differentiation). It is partly motivated by one concern, that were a group an ordered pair, changing its inside order would make a new group. My goal is to improve the ordered pair account. The order within functional units (e.g., leading unit) should be maintained, and the flexibility of non-orderedness among equally responsible individuals will be introduced. Here is a one supporting application. Suppose Tom and Joe are two are co-commanders in a squad, given my account, the mere difference of their position in a slice would not make different groups (while it would make two groups, given previous ordered pair account). Another motivation concerns the flexibility in persisting identity through time. To that purpose, I utilize the Lewisian model of four-dimensionalism, that a person is a collection of all his temporal slices (Lewis 1986, pp. 29, 38, 41, 53, 81). The one having 10^{10} atoms yesterday and the one having $10^{10}-1$ atoms today are just two temporal slices of mine.

[17] As discussed in Sheehy (2006), p. 18. Sheedy himself arguably rejects such a view.
[18] See Effingham (2010).
[19] See Ritchie (2020).
[20] See Wilhelm (2022).

Likewise, a group persists in various actions and each action could be considered as a slice.

Here is how the action condition works. Recall the democratic party case, that the democratic party organized a campaign yesterday having 10^8 members and the democratic party organizes a campaign today having 10^8+1 members. If those two actions, i.e., campaign organizations, are guided by one basic group intention called The Intention of Demos, then they're just two action slices of one group. A formulation of an action slice can be given as below. Grant the brain/brawn/bystander distinction (Gilbert 2006b, pp. 109–113)[21], that 'brains' are decision-makers, 'brawns' are operation carriers and 'bystander' are redundant in a certain (group) action. Suppose that there are degrees of being responsible. Let 'I' be the group intention for the action, '$C_1, \ldots, C_k, \ldots, C_m, \ldots, C_n$' be brains, '$H_1, \ldots, H_n$' be brawns and '$L_1, \ldots, L_n$' be bystanders. (Notice that entity like 'C_n' can also be taken as an action conducted by multiple individuals.) An action slice of group (denoted by 'S_A') could be:

(Case 1) $S_A =_{df} (I, (C_1, \ldots, C_n), (H_1, \ldots, H_n), (L_1, \ldots, L_n))$, where no two members are equally responsible for the action.

(Case 2) $S_A =_{df} (I, \{C_1, \ldots, C_n\}, (H_1, \ldots, H_n), (L_1, \ldots, L_n))$, where $C_1, \ldots, C_n$ are equally responsible, for any $i, j < n$ ($i \neq j$), H_i and H_j are not equally responsible for the action, neither do L_i and L_j.

(Case 3) $S_A =_{df} (I, (C_1, \ldots, \{C_k, \ldots, C_m\}, \ldots, C_n), (H_1, \ldots, H_n), (L_1, \ldots, L_n))$, where no two elements of $\{C_1, \ldots, C_n\} \setminus \{C_k, \ldots, C_m\}$ are equally responsible

[21] The Gilbert distinction is granted for its simplicity, intuitiveness and comprehensibility. There are of course other ways to fix the order of elements—e.g., a counter-factual analysis of each individual's contribution to the consequence of group action—that Group Grounding Middleism may presuppose.

while any two elements of $\{C_k, \ldots, C_m\}$ are equally responsible; for any i, j < n (i ≠ j), H_i and H_j are not equally responsible for the action, neither do L_i and L_j.

Case 1 is group action slice simpliciter. Case 2 and Case 3 are made to help illustrate how it works in cases with equally responsible members involved. It is understandable that real cases are much more complex, though the method utilized is the same. Last but not least, like many people, I still believe the existence—though not as prior as that of groups—of individuals. And I believe Group Grounding Middleism, though arguably controversial it is, needs not to presuppose the elimination of individuals. That's why I utilize a relatively moderate method (i.e., set theoretical language), albeit the Ramsey-Carnap-Lewis technique seems more preferrable for friends of deindividualization[22]. I will consider one challenge to both condition 2) and 3) later. Now we proceed to condition 3).

3) Structure Condition

My condition 3) says, a group has its unique structure, which is characterized as a collection of all its action slices (a set of ordered pairs) along with the bearers (members). Call it the structure condition. To motivate the structure condition is to answer two questions—why a collection of action slices, further, why along with its bearers? The answer to the first question naturally follows from condition 2), a Lewisian four-dimensionalism schema. And the location problem[23] gives raise to my

[22] See Dasgupta (2009), pp. 49–56, for the project of deindividualization and relevant formulation.
[23] See Effingham (2009), p. 257.

second answer. The location problem says, a group may share the same logical structure with a mathematic set, and it is mythical if a group is sole abstract as mathematical structure. I believe a logical structure with its bearers can make a group unique and such a Lewisian set—the group structure as mereological sum of multiple actions, which are in essence spatial-temporal—also indicates that a group is not necessarily bounded to platonic heaven[24]. And Now I'll propose a formulation of a complete structure of a group before I make further explanations. Let 'P_G' be the collection (of action slices) of a group 'G' and 'S_{A1}, S_{A2}, S_{A3}, …' be its action slices. We have: $P_G =_{df} \{S_{Ai} \mid i = 1, 2, 3, \ldots\}$. Notice that a collection of actions should be maximally accommodative. Otherwise, the collection could fail to identify groups. For example, let 'G_1' be a physics club in one high school class, and 'G_2' be a chemistry club having exactly the same member as 'G_1.' Consider two action slices. 'S_{A1}' is "taking a math class in order to improve quantities analyzing skill," and 'S_{A2}' is "having lunch together to stay healthy for scientific research." The collection 'P_G' is $\{S_{A1}, S_{A2}\}$ which cannot distinguish G_1 from G_2. A solution is not difficult to find. Consider another action slice 'S_{A3},' that "working on a Newton equation," we then have another collection 'P_G*,' that $\{S_{A1}, S_{A2}, S_{A3}\}$, which successfully tells G_1 from G_2.

On my account, the collection is a set (of ordered pairs) where the order of actions is not necessarily fixed. My reductio reasoning goes as below. Let the Lakers (the NBA basketball team) be the group, consider two actions— "training on October

[24] See Lewis (1991), pp. 31–33.

2nd, 2021" and "having a big meal on October 2nd, 2021." Let the order of elements (i.e., action slices) simply be temporal order. The group can have the training in the morning and have the meal in the night, or they can have the meal at noon and have the training in the afternoon. If the collection of action were ordered, we would then have two distinct collections. However, it seems that the essence of the Lakers doesn't change merely because the order of (two) actions changes. Therefore, the collection should not be ordered. Now I consider a challenge.

Despite my reductio argument, one counter-example of my proposal is still worth mentioning. Two distinct short-lived political parties, R_1 and R_2, share the same group intentions (basic and non-basic) and group members, and both organize two elections (which are all the actions they operate). And there are two clusters of people, P_1 and P_2. R_1 first organize P_1 for votes then organize P_2 for votes; while R_2 first organize P_2 for votes then organize P_1 for votes. It is reasonable to accuse my account of failing to tell R_1 from R_2, however, that failure is not too hard a bullet to bite. I argue my proposal is not defeated. The controversy, that whether R_1 and R_2 are identical, exists in a grey area of identity in general. Analogously, consider a pile of cobbles, before and after a rearrangement of cobbles, it is not clear whether two piles of cobbles are identical—at least their being (non-)identical invites debate.

2.3 Group Grounding Middleism

Thus far I have established that a group is an immanently structured collection of

action slices, equipped with a primitive group intention. In this section, provided my account of group identity, I flesh out a theory—i.e., Group Grounding Middleism—concerning how individuals are grounded in groups.

My general idea is that individuals are grounded in structures of groups. To better characterize this idea, I put my suggested conception of individuals on the table:

Individual. To be an individual is to be grounded in middle-levelled groups, which means

i) an individual action is grounded in (at least one) group action;

ii) an individual is grounded in the structure of (at least one) group;

iii) an individual is characterized in a collection of all his temporal slices.

Again, I argue each condition is reasonable.

i) Individual Action Condition

My condition i) says, an individual action is grounded in (at least one) group action. Call it the individual action condition. The individual action condition should answer two questions—why consider actions, and why regard group actions as grounds?

The first question is relatively easy. Provided my action-oriented account of group identity, individual actions are metaphysically innocent since they constitute group action slices[25]. The second question requires a revision of our common sense. I understand a stubborn intuition is there are individual actions that seemingly have

[25] It's note-worthy that an individual action is more coarse-grained than a temporal slice of an individual. For more precise demonstration, see my discussion of condition iii) in this section.

nothing to do with groups at all. For example, consider the action "Jack staying up late to study," what are the group action it is grounded in? Seemingly none. However, for a Group Grounding Middleist, the initial presumption is all individual actions are grounded in group actions. The presumption seems radical, but arguably defendable. For instance, I tentatively ground "Jack staying up late to study" in the group action "many senior high students trying to crack GMAT." This grounding relation seems natural, but arguably not unique. Assumably, one individual action could be grounded in multiple group actions. Beneath is my illustration.

Consider the individual action I_A "Isaac, a British white-collar, makes himself some tea and drinks it alone," and group actions like G_{A1} "British people have tea in the afternoon," G_{A2} "white-collars live a lonely but enjoyable life," etc. These groups actions are good candidates for being the grounds of the individual action. But how does the grounding relation hold exactly? Provided the full grounding/partial grounding distinction (Fine 2012, p. 50)—that given the intuitive notion of Δ (a set of facts) is fully grounded in Γ (another set of facts), Δ is partially grounded in Θ (a proper subset of Γ)—suppose the set $\{G_{A1}, G_{A2}\}$ is maximally accommodative for grounding facts of I_A, we can say the individual action I_A is fully grounded in groups actions $\{G_{A1}, G_{A2}\}$[26] and partly grounded in group action G_{A1}.

Another concern is that groups action that I refer like "British people have tea in

[26] It's understandable that most cases we encounter are partial-grounding relations, however, since the meta-metaphysical issue is not our emphasis, unless necessary, I will not distinguish full/partial grounding in following sections.

the afternoon" is dubiously a general description, not necessarily an action[27]. Here is my suggestion utilizing the action type/action token distinction[28]. Let G_{A1} remain "British people have tea in the afternoon" and let G_{A1}* be "5 million British people drink 5 million cups of tea, from time t_1 to t_2 across the UK." We can classify G_{A1}* as a token of G_{A1}. I_A can be further described as "Isaac, a British white-collar, makes himself some tea and drinks it alone, from 2 to 3 o'clock in West London." The grounding segment can be fleshed out as like. I_A is grounded in G_{A1}* and G_{A1}* is grounded in G_{A1}. A follow-up concern is how G_{A1}* could be a token of G_{A1}, for '5 million British people' is apparently not identical to 'British people.' My answer is the notion of 'British people' is also four-dimensionally constructed. '5 million British people' is one particular temporal slice—or one collection of temporal slices—of 'British people.' In virtue of phrasing elegance, later in this paper I will abbreviate group action tokens in the form of general descriptions, which is, though an abuse of language, more economic.

ii) Individual Place Condition

My condition ii) says, an individual is grounded in the structure of (at least one) group. Call it the individual place condition. Provided the structure condition in sec. 2.2, that a group has its unique structure that is characterized as a collection of all its

[27] A sloppy fix is to not distinguish action from general descriptions. Pragmatists about ground (e.g., Audi 2012) would not be too reluctant to embrace it, since we can intuitively put them in the in-virtue-of relation. But this fix seems verbal.

[28] It may presuppose a Davidsonian conception of actions that actions can be construed as objects. See Davidson (1963) for details.

action slices (a set of ordered pairs), and provided the grounding relation between individual action and group action, the individual place condition, arguably a metaphysical free lunch, appears to be a natural choice. I simply consider two concerns here. One concern is that the individual place condition is misleading, since an individual is arguably not defined in his actions. I argue, as the role one individual plays in a group action is classified by his function, a teleological position naturally follows. After all, our purpose is not to reveal the essence of individual—or roughly put, personhood. Another potential concern is somebody may have never played any role in any group actions. My answer is either that 'somebody' doesn't actually exist[29] (e.g., an orphan-baby dying young) or the grounding group action has not been discovered (e.g., the British white-collar case in this section).

iii) Individual Collection Condition

My condition iii) says, an individual is characterized in a collection of all his temporal slices. Call it the individual collection condition. The individual collection condition is supplementary to the four-dimensionalist schema suggested in sec. 2.2. In this section, my focus is to give a four-dimensional account of an individual from action slices of group actions (that we already defined).

My account goes like this. Let 'P' be the individuals, '$t_{P_i}^{n}$' be temporal slices of P

[29] A few more words on this issue. As far as we know, any (mammal) individual must have biological parents; therefore, the isolated individual assumption collapses. A vicious but possible case is, the parents died immediately after the birth of the baby. Two responses: either the baby is adopted and raised then he's not isolated, or it's unlikely for him to stay alive then the further assumptions—e.g., non-grouped actions—cannot exist.

(where i = 1, 2, 3, …, n), and 'A_{Pi}' be the action he acts that is grounded in certain group actions (where i = 1, 2, 3, …, n)—the collection of his temporal slices $\{t_{P1}^{1}, \ldots, t_{P1}^{n}\}$—corresponding to actions classified by different roles (e.g., C_n, H_n, I_n, see sec. 2.2). Granted that an individual is the collection of all its temporal slices throughout his persistence (the 4D claim), we have: $P =_{df} \{A_{P1}, \ldots, A_{Pi}\}$, a view featuring action slices; or $P =_{df} \{\{t_{P1}^{1}, \ldots, t_{P1}^{n}\}, \ldots, \{t_{Pi}^{1}, \ldots, t_{Pi}^{n}\}\}$, a view featuring temporal slices. This definition recollects some of one individual's temporal slices to formulate his action slices. To illustrate, let A_{P1} be 'be the brain C_1 of a group action S_{A1}' and $\{t_{P1}^{1}, \ldots, t_{P1}^{n}\}$ be all P's temporal slices in A_{P1}. Since a group action is also an action slice, given S_{A1} simpliciter (Case 1 in sec. 2.2), we have: $S_A =_{df} (I, (C_1, \ldots, C_n), (H_1, \ldots, H_n), (L_1, \ldots, L_n))$, the original version; or $S_A =_{df} (I, (A_{P1}, \ldots, C_n), (H_1, \ldots, H_n), (L_1, \ldots, L_n))$, one individualistic version; or $S_A =_{df} (I, (\{t_{P1}^{1}, \ldots, t_{P1}^{n}\}, \ldots), (H_1, \ldots, H_n), (L_1, \ldots, L_n))$, another individualistic version. Given this image, I believe there is no problem understanding my four-dimensional characterization of an individual grounded in the structure of groups. One last thing, following this characterization, a complete account of an individual might be complicated, i.e., tons of thousands of temporal slices. I have to point out that for most cases a fully detailed account is not necessary. However, if a complete version is required, then it takes what it has to take. That's the price of precision.

I have hitherto finished developing my proposal, viz. Group Grounding Middleism, that characterizes the ontological priority of groups over individuals. To apply

Group Grounding Middleism, later in section 3, I advance an account of group action and a theory of group responsibility, which, in comparison to previous account, may prove practically advantageous.

3 Two Applications

3.1 First Application: Group Action

My account of group action is simple—group actions, ontologically prior to individual actions, are primitive. In this section, I apply this account to the multiple-realization-like problem, a general problem of theories of group actions.

To introduce the problem, consider one group called Gang of Three, consisting of Axl, Bob and Cid. The group action is "to select Axl to be the leader," following the principle of majority (i.e., in this case Axl needs at least two votes), granted that everybody must vote for somebody (including himself), we have:

	votees						
Axl (voter)	Axl	Axl	Axl	Axl	Axl	Bob	Cid
Bob (voter)	Axl	Axl	Axl	Bob	Cid	Axl	Axl
Cid (voter)	Axl	Bob	Cid	Axl	Axl	Axl	Axl

Table. 1

There are seven distinct combinations to realize the group action. Then here comes a problem—in which combination is the group action grounded? It is—at least solely based on the group action—hard to say, and there is an overdetermination case. A formal demonstration goes like this. Let 'GA' be the group action and $\{I^i_{A1}, \ldots, I^i_{An}|$

i = 1, 2, 3, …, n} be the combination of individual actions. Provided theory entailing overdetermination should be rejected, given that GA can be grounded in $\{I^1_{A1}, \ldots, I^1_{An}\}$, or…, or $\{I^n_{A1}, \ldots, I^n_{An}\}$, the theory of aggregative/selective action entails over-determination and therefore should be rejected. This problem is general for theories of group action presupposing an individual-comes-first position. One possible (and ad hoc) response is to allow only token-talking. Each occurrence of a group action is de facto grounded in one combination of individual actions. However, it (unconsciously) postulates Necessitism—i.e., for any occurrence of a group action, it is grounded in the way it is ipso facto grounded and couldn't be grounded otherwise. This claim seems counterintuitive. Consider the voting case, given the group action is grounded in one combination, a common intuition is the group action could also be grounded in another six combinations[30]. Granted such an intuition for the sake of argument, I now clarify how Group Grounding Middleism can accommodate this intuition better.

In general, Group Grounding Middleists have two strategies to deal with the intuition in a multiple-realization-like case. Strategy one, they can reasonably embrace the intuition. Recall causation for comparison. Multiple causes leading to one effect is forbidden, however, one cause leading to multiple potential effects is allowed—e.g., "my being happy" may cause "my holding a party," "my treating people nicer," "my enjoying my life more," etc. Likewise, since a group-action type is prior to individual-action types (my overall stance), correspondingly, it could help ground multiple

[30] One may cast doubt upon this intuition by asking "why think 'the group action' refers to the token group action rather than the type group action?" I suspect the disagreement here is a clash of intuition.

potential combinations of individual-action types. In this sense, provided strategy one, the multiple-realization-like problem is dismissed. Strategy two, they can reject the intuition in virtue of the factiveness of grounding[31]. By "factiveness" I mean ground-talk doesn't allow for subjunctive, i.e., the relatas must be actual. That is to say, (pseudo-)ground-talks like "were I Adolf Hitler, it would help ground me cherishing my Jewish fellows" are not only ridiculous but also illegitimate. Given this notion, in reality, one group-action helps ground only one combination of individual-actions[32]. In this sense, provided strategy two, the multiple-realization-like problem is avoided.

3.2 Preparation: Responsibility Quantified

I develop the distributive theory of group responsibility deploying Group Grounding Middleism in following two sections. In section 3.2, I primarily deal with the quantification of moral responsibility, an initial problem of responsibility distribution.

Here I do not intend to argue for the nature of responsibility[33]. Usually, though not non-controversially, philosophers construe moral responsibilities to be something property-like[34] allowing for degrees. But the degree of moral responsibility is not as cut and dry as the degree of redness, which is measured by a unified scale in terms of

[31] See Correa and Schnieder (2012), p. 22.
[32] This claim may invite the debate of Necessitism, where I believe there are resources in favor of my proposal. Space limited, I stop the inquiry here in this paper.
[33] Philosophers are in fact quite ambiguous about the nature of moral responsibility.
[34] E.g., moral responsibility as a property called answerability such that "to be morally responsible for Φ is to be answerable for Φ" (cf. Shoemaker 2011, p. 603).

shades. We have reasons to doubt whether the moral responsibility of Hitler's genocide is measured under the same scale as the moral responsibility of my being late for class. Call two entities "commensurable" if they can be measured under the same scale. For Group Grounding Middleism, group and group responsibility are ontologically prior to individual and individual responsibility, which implies individual responsibility is derived from group responsibility. Thus, a necessary presumption of Group Grounding Middleism is that, in general, responsibilities should be commensurable. What's more, commeasured responsibilities of group should be quantified, divided and then distributed to individuals. In paragraphs below, I would show to what degree should a Group Grounding Middleist involve in the debate concerning the incommensurability of values (step one) and how responsibilities could be quantified (step two).

Step one, a Group Grounding Middleist should argue that responsibilities are in general commensurable. To this point, a Group Grounding Middleist should at least take side with ethicists who reject the notion of incommensurability—that two values, *a* and *b*, when compared with respect to a certain dimension (e.g., impressiveness), neither "*a* is better than *b*," nor "*b* is better than *a*," nor "*a* and *b* are equally good" is true[35]. A few resources are at issue. First, a Group Grounding Middleist could cast doubt upon the justification of incommensurability thesis, for example, they may argue that the argument conducting incommensurability is invalid[36]. Second, a Group

[35] See, for further information, Chang (2013).
[36] See, e.g., Gustafsson and Espinoza (2010).

Grounding Middleist could argue that in normal cases (i.e., non-moral dilemma cases), the notion of comparability (a sufficient condition of commensurability) is in general true and logically non-rejectable[37]. As is seen, Group Grounding Middleist may have burden defending the claim, that responsibilities are in general commensurable, but the engagement in the debate concerning incommensurability shall not flaw the project.

Step two, a Group Grounding Middleist should argue for how responsibilities are quantified. Below is a method to represent and quantify responsibility. Analogously, Fuji Mountain has a height (neglecting the problem of vagueness), which could be represented in 'meters.' And historically, the representation is conducted, briefly put, by comparing the height of the mountain with the length of a stick in Paris, and the process resembles my intended method of representing and quantifying responsibility. A Group Grounding Middleist does not have to care about exactly how much responsibilities are there in reality (analogously, the actual height of Fuji Mountain), since genuine group responsibilities is initially presupposed. The focus, therefore, falls on means of representing responsibilities (analogously, the stick for measurement). And an inspiration from measuring social utility is available: that to quantify utility is to represent social welfare in some functional objects like house, cloths, etc. And an economic model, built upon those factors (i.e., functional collective choice rule), can accordingly characterize the well-being of a person or the whole society[38]. Likewise, to

[37] See, e.g., Dorr, Nebel and Zuehl (forthcoming).
[38] See Sen (1970), pp. 313–315, 317, 330, 447–448.

represent the group responsibility, a general idea is, bad effects of actions can be represented in physical harms, damages of property and emotional harms. With assignments of value to particular effects under those categories, the representation of total bad effects of actions can be generated[39]. The image I present lacks a great many details concerning relevant distinctions and debates. Nevertheless, my purpose here is merely to explore the possibility of quantifying responsibilities. A general picture, therefore, suffices for demonstration, albeit the application of this general idea is almost certainly laborious and the result is assumably open for criticism. Again, Group Grounding Middleist may have burden realizing the quantification, but such difficulty shall not flaw the project. Granted that responsibilities are quantified for the sake of later discussion, I finally define the unit for measuring responsibility, reo (denoted by 'ρ') as the minimal unit of responsibility—the aliquot part of any amount of responsibility of anyone in any action.

3.3 Second Application: Group Responsibility

In section 3.3, I define distributive function of responsibility and provide three examples helping explain its advantages.

A distributive function of responsibility is a mapping from group responsibility to individual(s). Let $\{\rho_1, \ldots, \rho_n\}$ be the group responsibility of a certain action (denoted by 'a'), and $m_1, \ldots, m_q$ be all the individuals involved. Given that the relation between

[39] It accusably poses a consequentialist schema. Considering the representative nature of my method, I do not think the involvement flaws my theory.

group responsibility and individual responsibility is characterized by a distributive function, we have three definitions as below:

Distributive criterion. One person is held responsible in different degrees considering the role he played in a (group) action, given a certain classification; and in one distribution only one criterion is allowed.

Distributive function. A distributive function of responsibility in a certain action (denoted by 'F^a_D') is a mapping from a subset of the group responsibility into a subset of all individuals involved; it can be formulated as F^a_D: W→Z, where W is a subset of $\{\rho_1, \ldots, \rho_n\}$ and Z is a subset of $\{m_1, \ldots, m_q\}$.

Distributive responsibility. The responsibility of an individual of a group in a certain action is some amount of reos distributed from the group responsibility.

To illustrate how my theory works, let's consider three cases[40].

The distributive function could be a bijection, where each member is equally responsible, and the group responsibility is nothing over and above the sum of individual responsibilities. Consider *Case One*. Again, Axl, Bob and Cid—Gang of Three—are our heroes. We have three individual action "Axl broke a glass," "Bob broke a glass" and "Cid broke a glass." And the group action is "Gang of Three broke three glasses." The distributive function of responsibility is:

Group responsibility	$\{\{\rho^1_1, \ldots, \rho^1_n\},$	$\{\rho^2_1, \ldots, \rho^2_n\},$	$\{\rho^3_1, \ldots, \rho^3_n\}\}$
	↓	↓	↓
Group members	Axl	Bob	Cid

Diagram. 1

[40] Those are arguably three (over-)simplified cases, but from those cases the general pattern of analysis can be seen.

The distributive function could be an injection, where group responsibility is the sum of individual responsibility while not every individual in the group should be held responsible. Consider *Case Two*—the German Guilt case. The group 'Nazi Germany' is held responsible for 6 billion deaths. We have two individuals, Adolf Hitler and the 9-year-old girl, Hannah, who happened to be born in 1934. Then, suppose Hannah is not responsible, the distributive function is:

Group responsibility	$\{\{\rho^1_1, \ldots, \rho^1_n\},$	$\ldots\}$	
	↓	↓	
Group members	{Adolf Hitler,	…},	Hannah
	W_G (a subset of Nazi Germen)		

Diagram. 2

The distributive function could be a surjection, where the groups responsibility is more than just the sum of individual responsibilities. One may think it is unbelievable, but it is not unreal: consider *Case Three*—the La Guardia Case. During Great Depression, an old granny stole a loaf of bread because of the systematic poverty in the society, for which, as La Guardia (the mayor of New York City) argues, all New York citizens were found guilty. There are responsibilities assigned to the society (granted as a group agent), however, any arbitrary New Yorker is intuitively not responsible for "letting the old granny steal." The distributive function is:

Group responsibility	$\{\{\rho^1_1, \ldots, \rho^1_n\},$	$\ldots, \{\rho^n_1, \ldots, \rho^n_n\}\}$
	↓	
Group members	$\{m_1, \ldots, m_q\}$	
	(New Yorkers)	

Diagram. 3

Now I demonstrate the advantage of a distributive approach. In the La Guardia Case,

as one may argue, that no New-Yorker him-/herself is responsible (i.e., no individual responsibility), from which the derivation of group responsibility seems mythical but inevitable—since many theories presuppose the ontological priority of individual responsibility over group responsibility. By contrast, given the distributive theory of group responsibility, the distributive function is then a mapping from the set of group responsibility into a null set, which is of course a subset of {All New Yorkers}. Our intuition is therefore accommodated, and such accommodation is my rationale of a distributive approach.

I eventually consider an objection about the responsibility of a seemingly non-group action. Consider "one white policeman kills an unarmed black man," which group, if any, should be held responsible for this misconduct? Several candidates are at issue, for instance, "some white people discriminate," "the police system encourages violence," etc. If so, it seems not too bizarre to say the white policeman kills an unarmed black man because the white community neglects the threat of racism, or because the police force lacks guidance and restriction on police brutality. A Group Grounding Middleist should further argue that the responsibility of groups like white community is more basic than the responsibility of the killer. Suppose, for simplicity, the group action "some white people are discriminative" fully grounds the individual action "one white policeman kills an unarmed black man,"[41] a line of reasoning goes like this. Had the white community not discriminated, suppose other things (like the

[41] In reality there are usually multiple distributing chains for an individual action. The problem of distributing reos to multiple grounding chains is, though significant, arguably the subject of another project and is therefore ignored.

possibility of car accidents, etc.) do not influence the result (i.e., the black man being killed), white men (including the policeman) would be impartial to ethnicity, and the black man would still be alive. Had the white community discriminated, however, even if the white policeman had not pulled the trigger, another white racist could kill the black man, too. This case—a paradigmatic case—seems not too controversial. A Group Grounding Middleist has to admit that it still takes efforts to generalize the conclusion, that all individual responsibilities are derived from group responsibilities, to many more controversial cases regarding seemingly bare individuals. Nonetheless, as is shown in cases I present ("Jack staying up late to study" and "one white policeman kills an unarmed black man"), such a generalization is possible—and is even not as difficult as is assumed.

4 Concluding Remarks

To summarize, in this paper, I primarily develop my proposal, a.k.a. Group Grounding Middleism, that an individual is grounded in his temporal slices (of actions), an individual action is grounded in its position in a group action (slice), and a group, identified and individuated by a fundamental group intention, is characterized by the collection of its action slices (sec. 2). I then illustrate how explanations deploying Group Grounding Middleism, one about group agency and the other about group responsibility, could prove advantageous in practice (sec. 3).

I know Group Grounding Middleism is a daring proposal. To defend it, one may

also commit himself to structuralism, four-dimensionalism, and many other controversial theses. This cost may trouble sympathizers of my proposal, but it may also make my proposal more appealing for original supporters of those theses. My exploration is done. It is now my readers' option to take my proposal or leave it. Nevertheless, I believe this paper would, even if not decisively, at least motivate philosophers to reexamine our talks about individual-group priority and those theories built upon individual priority. In that sense, my writing could work as a blueprint.

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